

September 27, 2023

Memo #5

Starting with prior knowledge and background information, race has always been a way for society to place groups of people in power over other groups of people, which is the social tendency of civilizations to be in a “better” state as opposed to other civilizations. Greed is definitely the reason why civilizations could never coincide without trying to take advantage of other resources outside of their origins. Looking at history, the only reason race became connotated with inequality and oppression is because of civilization clashes caused by the social concept of greed or having more than the other person. The people of darker skin colors were from areas near the equator, thus they needed more melanin in order to survive the sun’s radiation. Near the equator is also where the best crop, soil, and ecosystems were found, so other civilizations wanted to exploit these places for their benefit. Because exploitation means taking without proper compensation, these people from the rich lands were also seen as people to be exploited by other civilizations, further cementing the invading civilizations as people being driven by greed for power. The idea of race comes from this agenda of power, where people on the other spectrum of greed ended up being the “darker” races while the “lighter” races were seen as superior. Nowadays, the concept of race from greed still exists, with those preconceived notions of the culture and community of different races being stereotyped by others. This example is similar to the examples presented in the Haney Lopez, where in the example of the Wright family, their “Black” racial heritage was seen as a connotation to them being descended or related to people forced into slavery, which is not a stereotype started because of their color, but because of the fact that their ancestors were the oppressed population and therefore seen as inferior to the “powerful” race or oppressive civilization, conceiving ill biases towards them simply because of their race. The concept of skin color is biological, but the concept of race is social and solely present because of the pursuit for power. Race may be connotated to skin color, but the original meaning behind differentiating by race was meant to put one civilization superior to all others.

Question: Just as race was socially constructed to oppress, do you think that in a similar way, race can be reconstructed to uplift, or will the burden of past definitions always be present when bringing up race?